

DECODED EXPLAINED

10th August, 2026

A New Security Triangle Emerges With the Makkah Pact

A new security triangle emerges with the Makkah Pact

The Makkah Joint Defence Agreement (MJDA), signed on August 7, 2026, by the top leaders of Saudi Arabia, Türkiye and Pakistan, is the first regional realignment since the geostrategic tsunami of the United States-Iran war. While the MJDA text has not been revealed, the joint statement issued specifically states that "any armed attack against any one of the three states shall be regarded as an attack against them all".

This echoes infamous Article 5 of the North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO) – never invoked – leading speculators to claim that the MJDA was a harbinger of a "Muslim NATO". It appears to be part of a jerky Saudi response to specific security challenges, including a Strategic Mutual Defence Agreement (SMDA) with Pakistan last year and a 14-country Multinational Maritime Defence Alliance (MMDA) in the last week of July.

Shifting alignments, uncertain stakes

Any analysis of the MJDA faces multiple uncertainties, including ongoing regional turbulence, partners' previous karma, and their varied expectations. This hazy context creates a push-pull effect: from anticipation of the MJDA having profound cascading implications to it being a seemingly desultory, inconsequential response to their asymmetric defence and security challenges. Some also see it as inducing counter-polarisation and alarming other stakeholders from Iran and its non-state allies, Israel, Kurds, and Greece to the United Arab Emirates and India. To walk back, the Saudi Deputy Foreign Minister has clarified that it is neither an effort to establish a military axis nor a sectarian bloc. He denied any link to nuclear ambitions or an arms race.

This denial is unlikely to pierce the statement's conspicuous silence about the precise threats that the MJDA is geared to confront, the U.S.-Iran war roiling the region, Israeli aggressiveness, threats from the non-state actors, and the impact of choke point constrictions. It also refrains from either inviting like-minded regional powers to join in or an uplink with the existing collective security architectures provided by the Arab League, the Organisation of Islamic Cooperation and the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC).

Observers point out that the Arab-Muslim world has remained divided against Israel for close to eight decades. Hence, the prospect of the MJDA being a precursor to a Muslim NATO polarised against Iran and its Arab proxies appears far-fetched at this stage. Moreover, even as all three MJDA signatories are allies of the U.S. (which remains suspiciously silent), it is unclear if it is meant to substitute the regional Pax Americana or to serve as a surrogate for the *ancien régime*. In the same vein, if the proposed Muslim NATO in future decides to confront Israel, the U.S. would have scored its own goal.

Moreover, the MJDA is beset by various snags. The Saudis have bitter memories of the Ottoman



Mahesh Sachdev
Retired Indian
Ambassador,
specialising in the
Arab world and
oil issues

rule, which brutally suppressed the Al-Saud. For similar reasons, from Türkiye, Ankara's boots on the ground have been shunned by most post-independence Arab regimes.

Till recently, Türkiye promoted the Sunni outfits such as the Muslim Brotherhood, Hamas and motley Syrian militias, many of which are anathema to the Gulf regimes. Türkiye's President Recep Tayyip Erdoğan's Neo-Ottoman ambitions to lead the Sunni Islamic world collide with the Kingdom's self-image of being the Custodian of Islam's Two Holiest Shrines. Riyadh does not contenance playing second fiddle to Turkey or any other Muslim power. President Erdoğan had a testy relationship with Saudi Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman (MbS) over the 2018 murder of Jamal Khashoggi, a U.S.-based Saudi journalist, in the Saudi consulate in Istanbul. Turkish leaks on this episode sullied MbS's image, making him a western outlier.

On the other hand, Pakistani troop deployments in Saudi Arabia in the past resulted in frictions due to chain of command disputes, Islamabad's refusal to have its troops shorn of Shias and its reluctance to confront Iran or Yemen. Armed forces in Türkiye and Pakistan have a long-standing tradition of Bonapartism. Saudis have kept armed forces and the National Guard, both with an American-styled set up, out of politics since the Ikhwān militia insurrection (the late 1920s) and the Makkah siege of 1979. Both Türkiye and Pakistan have an active border with Iran – offering a potentially lucrative post-war economic bonanza that they would be loath to forego. Pakistan's enthusiasm for the MJDA is circumscribed by its 900 kilometre-long border with Iran, a large Shia minority, internal security challenges and hostility with India and Afghanistan. In a typical doublespeak, last week, Pakistan began formal discussions on a Free Trade Agreement with Iran, notwithstanding the U.S. sanctions, the MJDA and the SMDA.

Riyadh's security needs

The MJDA is clearly fulcrumed around Saudi security requirements, which Riyadh expects Türkiye and Pakistan to mitigate as part of a "friends with benefits" arrangement. However, the current threats faced by Saudi Arabia are complex and asymmetric, ranging from air attacks on its vital and vulnerable oil and civil infrastructure by Iran and its proxies, the closures of the Strait of Hormuz and Bab al-Mandeb and the possible insurrection by the restive Shia minority. It is unclear if Türkiye and Pakistan can meet such challenges, where the U.S. Central Command, with its large, long-standing presence and state-of-the-art equipment, failed. The new allies could perhaps upstage the U.S. in having more boots on the ground in Saudi Arabia, but the Kingdom is unlikely to face a ground invasion. Moreover, relying on foreign forces to address internal security challenges would be bad optics for the

Kingdom. The foregoing is not to deride the MJDA as merely a cosmetic exercise. It symbolises the congruence of the three large Sunni powers with considerable complementarity: the Saudi \$83 billion defence budget, Türkiye's booming military industrial complex exporting \$10 billion annually and Pakistan's 6,60,000-strong armed forces. Their defence and security cross-pollination through military exercises, interoperability of weapon systems and co-production and development of hardware would be beneficial to them all. Additionally, Türkiye and Pakistan could gain political influence in the Kingdom and enrich themselves.

At this stage, the MJDA's future appears uncertain. It may flourish if a low-burn attrition war continues to ripple through the region. Ironically, if an all-out shooting war breaks out, Türkiye and Pakistan may be hesitant to commit forces against Iran, their neighbour. At the other end, if peace prevails, the MJDA would become superfluous. A market share scrimmage among the oil exporters would create a glut, affecting the Saudi capacity to bankroll the MJDA partners.

Having suffered Iranian doggedness and Trumpian tantrums, Saudi Arabia and other Gulf Arabs are currently experimenting with various security alternatives. The Saudis began the SMDA with Pakistan last year and have felt the need for an MMDA and MJDA. They do not appear to be playing a zero-sum game between semi-reliable Pakistan and India. U.S. President Donald Trump's unreliability was on full display to the Saudis recently in his last-minute Abraham Accords rider to the recent nuclear agreement with the Kingdom. The Saudis may not wish to further complicate their dependence on Uncle Sam by deepening their entanglement with Ankara and Islamabad, both ultimately subject to Washington's dictates.

The implications for India

Depending on various scenarios panning out, the MJDA can impact India's interests in multiple ways. While India needs to keep a steady eye on Pakistan's attempt to align the MJDA partners with it against India, New Delhi should not overreact. As the world's third-largest crude oil importer, India is slated to drive global demand for the next 15 years. India has been the Kingdom's third-largest market and second largest trading partner. Like Saudi Arabia, India has been both a consistent and moderate pro-status quo power amenable to simpler paradigms of economic complementarity.

Riyadh finds ties with India uncluttered by extraneous considerations. India is a geo-strategically safe bet for the turbulent Gulf. Riyadh, facing a huge paradigm shift, is most unlikely to wade into supporting Pakistan's adventurism against India. So, while the MJDA may give Islamabad an adrenaline high, Pakistan's quest to match India's rise through military fluster in West Asia is unlikely to succeed.

Depending on how different scenarios unfold, the Makkah Joint Defence Agreement (MJDA) could affect India's interests in several ways

A New Security Triangle Emerges With the Makkah Pact

The MJDA builds on the Saudi-Pakistan Strategic Mutual Defence Agreement (SMDA) signed in September 2025.

Saudi Arabia, Türkiye and Pakistan signed the Makkah Joint Defence Agreement (MJDA) at Al-Safa Palace in Makkah, Saudi Arabia. The agreement states that an armed attack against any one of the three countries will be regarded as an attack against all three.

The pact has been described as a new “triple alliance” or “Sunni security triangle” aimed at strengthening collective defence and security cooperation.

The Makkah Joint Defence Agreement (MJDA) between Saudi Arabia, Türkiye and Pakistan strengthens collective defence and reflects the emergence of a more multipolar West Asian security architecture.

The pact states that an armed attack against one member will be regarded as an attack against all three, creating a collective-deterrence commitment.

Its principle resembles North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO) Article 5 mutual-defence provision

A New Security Triangle Emerges With the Makkah Pact

Why such a move ?

- 1. Hedging Against a Retreating "Pax Americana"**
- 2. Saudi Arabia's Interests : Houthi attacks in Yemen and the Red Sea, along with risks around the Strait of Hormuz and Bab-el-Mandeb. Greater security is therefore important for protecting oil exports, investment, tourism and Vision 2030.**
- 3. Türkiye's Interests: Türkiye views Israel's expanding military presence in Gaza and Syria**
- 4. Pakistan's Interests: Pakistan gains greater strategic relevance in West Asia**

A New Security Triangle Emerges With the Makkah Pact

What should India do ?

- 1. De-risk and Recalibrate Minilateralism: India must practice strategic patience regarding the India–Middle East–Europe Economic Corridor (IMEC) and I2U2.**
- 2. Calibrate the Iranian Transit Axis: While Chabahar Port and the International North-South Transport Corridor (INSTC) remain vital long-term assets for Central Asian access**
- 3. Diversify Gulf Partnerships: Deepen defence, maritime security and technology cooperation with UAE, Oman and Qatar so that India's West Asia strategy is not dependent on any single country.**
- 4. Build Indigenous Defence Capabilities**
- 5. Strengthen Indian Ocean Security**

A New Security Triangle Emerges With the Makkah Pact

India and Iran signed a 10-year contract for operating the Chabahar port in Iran.

Chabahar is Iran's oceanic port nearest to India. It is situated in Sistan and Baluchistan Province, on the Makran coast. It lies in the Gulf of Oman.

Chabahar Port project has two main ports called the Shahid Kalantari Port and the Shahid Beheshti Port.

In May 2016, India, Iran, and Afghanistan signed a trilateral agreement to establish the International Transport and Transit Corridor, also known as the Chabahar Agreement.

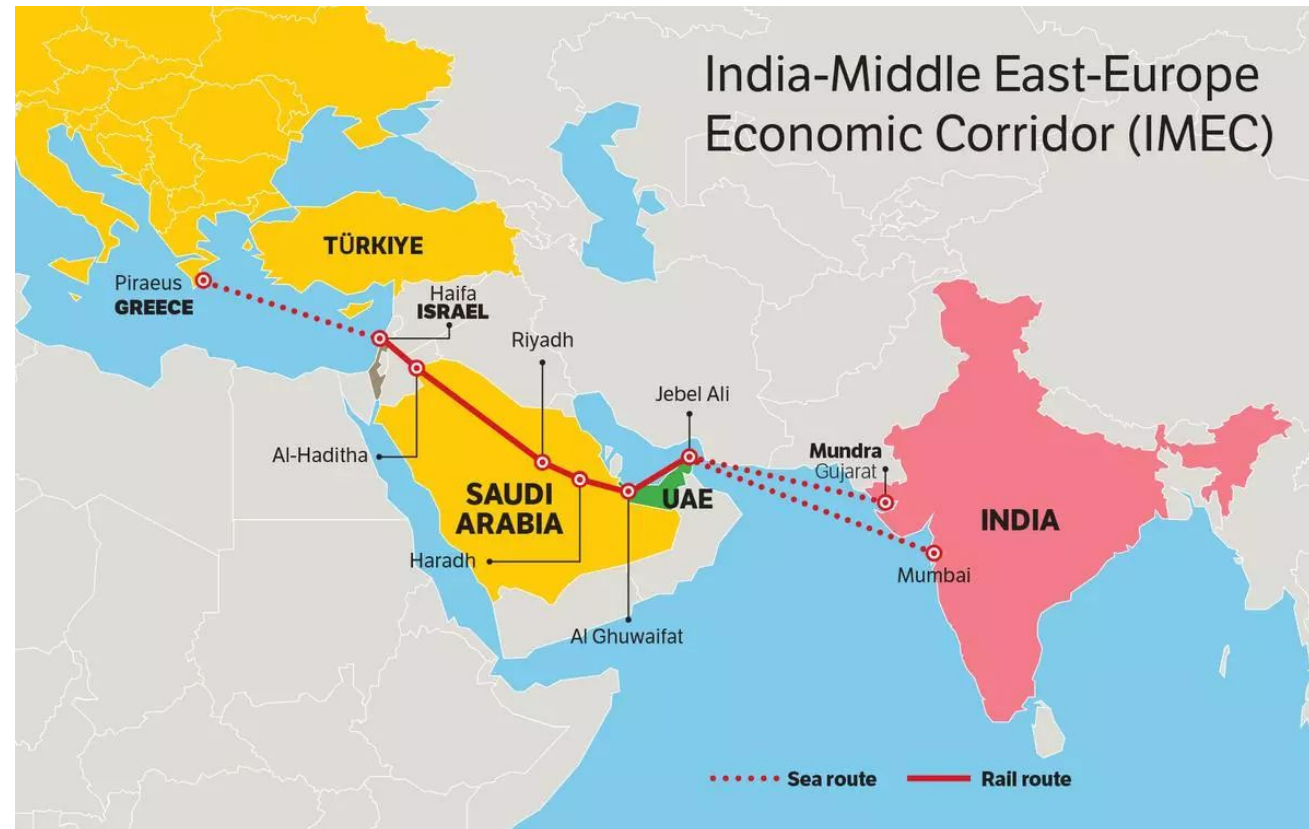


A New Security Triangle Emerges With the Makkah Pact

The IMEC is a strategic multi-modal connectivity initiative launched through a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) during the G20 Summit 2023 in New Delhi. Signatories include India, US, Saudi Arabia, the United Arab Emirates, France, Germany, Italy and the European Union.

IMEC seeks to position itself as a viable alternative to China's Belt and Road Initiative (BRI) by promoting transparent, sustainable, and debt-free infrastructure without compromising national sovereignty.

IMEC has two parts the Eastern Corridor (India to Gulf) and the Northern Corridor (Gulf to Europe).



A New Security Triangle Emerges With the Makkah Pact

Q. What is the importance of developing Chabahar Port by India? (2017)

- (a)** India's trade with African countries will enormously increase.
- (b)** India's relations with oil-producing Arab countries will be strengthened.
- (c)** India will not depend on Pakistan for access to Afghanistan and Central Asia.
- (d)** Pakistan will facilitate and protect the installation of a gas pipeline between Iraq and India.

A Common Blueprint for India's Industrial Heat Electrification

A common blueprint for India's industrial heat electrification

India's next phase of energy transition must focus on electrifying industrial heat; a coordinated approach involving innovative financing, skilled workers, demonstration projects and cluster-level planning can help scale the transition and strengthen manufacturing competitiveness

Yrinda Gupta
Srinivas Ethiraj

India's energy transition is already mainstreaming renewable-powered electrification across major demand centres. Electric mobility is replacing internal combustion engines, agriculture is increasingly powered by solar irrigation, and buildings are adopting smarter appliances. The next phase lies in electrifying industrial heat, particularly across India's MSMEs, to strengthen manufacturing competitiveness, energy security and decarbonisation.

India's solar photovoltaic revolution reduced solar tariffs by more than 85% over the past decade through a coordinated ecosystem of supportive policies both at the national and state level, innovative financing, competitive vendors and markets, institutional mandates, and sustained private sector investment. Now, scaling industrial heat electrification will require a similar approach. The focus has shifted to how India plans and scales this transition.

No blanket solution

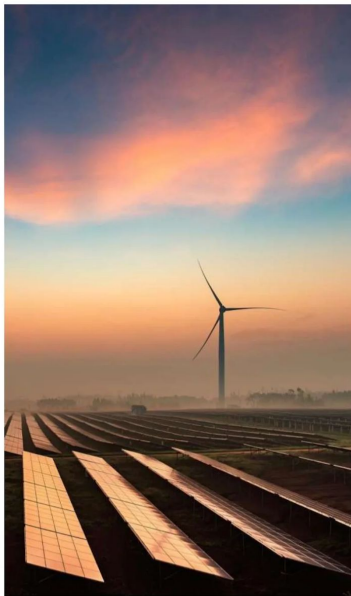
First, facility-level engineering assessments should become the foundation of industrial heat electrification. Most industries have limited visibility of their thermal systems beyond fuel consumption. Steam flow is rarely metered, process temperatures are often unmonitored, and waste heat streams remain unquantified. Without robust engineering assessments, industries risk investing in technologies unsuited to their process requirements. So, engineering assessments should evaluate legacy boiler performance and operating costs, optimise steam systems, identify recoverable waste heat, and where feasible, replace steam with more efficient direct heating before electrification.

Electricity can be used only where it delivers the greatest value. So, process integration tools such as pinch analysis should identify internal heat recovery opportunities before electrification.

Representative facilities can be used to develop standardised process profiles that estimate hourly thermal demand, identify electrifiable heat loads, and inform future electricity demand for utilities and grid operators. Aggregated across industrial clusters, these assessments can support district-level industrial decarbonisation plans tailored to local industrial profiles, renewable resources, and infrastructure readiness. Localised planning recognises that there is no one-size-fits-all solution.

Second, India should adopt a technology-inclusive approach. Industrial processes vary widely in temperature, production schedules, and thermal demand. So a single technology solution is impractical.

Heat pumps are well suited for low- and medium-temperature applications, particularly where waste heat can be recovered. Electric boilers currently offer a practical pathway for steam generation above 200°C. Mechanical vapour recompression systems can recover and reuse process vapour in evaporation-intensive processes. Thermal energy storage solutions can act as thermal buffers by storing surplus heat generated when renewable electricity is



Powering up: A successful electrification programme hinges on affordable and reliable renewable electricity supply. (© Getty Images)

abundant or recovered from industrial waste heat, and releasing it when process heat is required, improving operational flexibility and reducing peak electricity demand.

Access to capital

Third, a successful electrification programme hinges on affordable and reliable renewable electricity supply.

While renewable generation costs have fallen dramatically over the past decade, the delivered cost of renewable electricity for industries remains influenced by network charges, open-access provisions, and other transaction costs.

As India's commercial and industrial renewable energy market matures, reforms should focus on reducing these costs by streamlining open-access procedures, rationalising banking provisions, reducing transactional complexity, and strengthening grid infrastructure, particularly for electrification projects that replace fossil

The right fit

The following criteria can help identify brownfield units best suited for early deployment of low- and medium-temperature electrification technologies.

Screening criterion	Indicative threshold
Steam generation cost	< ₹2.5 per kg of steam
Steam-to-fuel ratio	< 3 kg steam per kg fuel
Recoverable waste heat	Temperature > 50°C; flow rate > 60 cubic metres per hour
Delivered cost of renewable electricity	< ₹6 per kWh
Boiler service life	> 18 years

fuel-based heating. Renewable electricity planning should be integrated with industrial electrification, enabling industries to align thermal demand with periods of renewable generation. Fourth, financing models must evolve

alongside technologies. The principal challenge in scaling industrial heat electrification extends beyond technology to reducing engineering and investment risks, particularly for MSMEs with limited access to capital and technical expertise.

Technology leasing, heat-as-a-service, energy service company models, and blended finance can lower the upfront investment and technology risks. Equally important is demand aggregation.

Facility-level assessments should feed into cluster-level investment pipelines, allowing industries with similar thermal profiles to aggregate demand, reduce procurement costs, and improve access to low-cost finance.

Demonstration projects

Fifth, India needs skilled workers and implementation capacity tailored to cluster needs. Many industries, particularly MSMEs, face capability and skill gaps that slow technology adoption, reduce efficiency, and limit innovation. Most of the vocational and industry training programmes often focus on routine operations and maintenance. Industrial heat electrification will require an engineering transition at the shop floors rather than a simple equipment replacement exercise. Scaling it requires a workforce of engineers, technicians, and operators with capabilities in process integration, system design, installation, commissioning, operation, and maintenance, and digital automation and control systems.

Sixth, India needs demonstration projects before it needs large-scale mandates. India needs first-of-its-kind demonstration projects across representative sectors, process temperatures, and industrial clusters. This will generate engineering evidence, validate business models, and reduce investment uncertainty. The priority should be to identify the most suitable first-mover facilities.

Based on our analysis in brownfield settings, units that meet these screening criteria are the best candidates for early deployment of low- and medium-temperature (up to 250°C) electrification technologies (Table 1).

Common blueprint

Finally, industrial heat electrification needs a coordinated national framework supported by place-based implementation. It should establish engineering standards, designate institutional responsibility, facilitate demand aggregation, mobilise finance, and support early demonstration projects. Its implementation should be driven through district and cluster-level industrial energy transition plans, allowing each industrial cluster to transition according to its unique thermal profile, local context, electricity market, and renewable energy potential.

India now needs a common blueprint to transform industrial heat electrification into a scalable industrial strategy. Industrial heat offers an opportunity to decarbonise manufacturing, reduce greenhouse gas emissions, and build a more resilient and future-ready industrial economy.

(Yrinda Gupta is associate director, Energy Transition, Vasudha Foundation; Srinivas Ethiraj is assistant manager, Energy Transition, Vasudha Foundation)

Glueball: Matter of Force

Glueball: matter of force

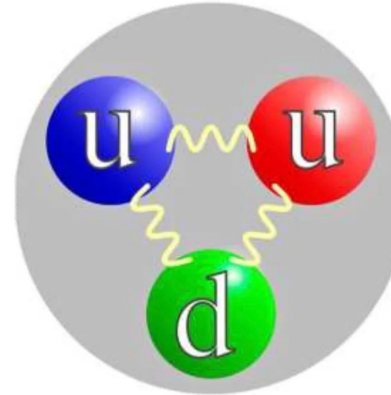
Vasudevan Mukunth

Nature has four fundamental forces: gravity, the weak force (responsible for radioactivity), electromagnetism, and the strong force. The strong force is responsible for keeping the protons and neutrons together in the nuclei of atoms.

The theory describing the strong interaction between two particles is called quantum chromodynamics (QCD). In QCD, the strong force is carried by gluons — just like how the electromagnetic force is carried by photons. But unlike photons, gluons carry a kind of charge that allows gluons to be attracted to each other. And QCD says they can come together to form composite particles called glueballs.

In new research, scientists have taken a big step closer to showing glueballs exist. The team used data from the BESIII experiment in Beijing to uncover them. This is easier said than done because when a glueball appears in a particle physics experiment, it will be very short-lived and quickly decay into lighter particles in a way that is hard to distinguish from some other particles.

Scientists had first observed a candidate glueball called X(2370) in BESIII data in 2011. Its mass seemed consistent with a glueball. They also estimated some of its properties based on the decays of a particle called the J/ψ meson. The new data buttresses the odds that



Protons are made up of three smaller particles called quarks, held together by the strong interaction mediated by particles called gluons.

ARPAD HORVATH (CC BY-SA)

X(2370) is indeed a glueball by revealing more properties glueballs possess.

Thus, BESIII has assembled the strongest case to date that X(2370) has a dominant glueball component, potentially providing the first evidence for a form of matter made just from the carriers of a fundamental force.

For feedback and suggestions
for 'Science', please write to
science@thehindu.co.in with the
subject 'Daily page'

The Stakes in India's Delimitation Debate

The stakes in India's delimitation debate

What triggers delimitation? How will the 2027 Census affect seat allocation? Can the exercise be completed before 2029? Which States could gain or lose seats? What happens without a constitutional amendment? How will women's reservation be implemented? How can new boundaries affect electoral outcomes?

EXPLAINER

Varghese K. George

The story so far:

The 1971 is known to kick off a fresh delimitation of Lok Sabha constituencies. It is trying to generate a two-third majority in Parliament to pass a Constitutional amendment for this purpose. In April 2026, it had moved the amendment but could not pass it. The Centre has not revealed its exact proposals. The proposal that the Centre placed before Parliament in the previous Session were the following: 1) Increase the size of the Lok Sabha up to a maximum of 850 seats; 2) distribute these seats among the States based on the 2011 Census through a fresh, countrywide delimitation of constituencies; and 3) reserve one-third of the total seats for women.

According to the existing Constitutional provisions, a fresh delimitation is possible only after the data of the 2027 Census is published, and reservation for women can be rolled out only along with it.

What happens if there is no Constitutional amendment?

For a fresh delimitation to happen, a Constitutional amendment is not required. A fresh delimitation will be triggered soon after the data of the 2027 census is published. The terms for the next delimitation are already written into the Constitution, principally in Articles 81 and 82. A Constitutional amendment is required only if the existing constitutional provisions relating to delimitation are to be changed.

Articles 81 and 82 mandate that after the data from the first Census conducted after 2026 is published, two things will happen: The first is a reallocation of the existing strength of the Lok Sabha among the States and Union Territories on the basis of the population recorded in that Census, which would, in this case, be the 2027 Census. The second is the delimitation of individual constituencies within each State. Therefore, if there is no Constitutional amendment at all, there will be a delimitation exercise that must begin after the data of the 2027 Census is published.



Gearing up: A fresh delimitation will be triggered soon after the data of the 2027 census is published. Source: Kishan Varma

Can a fresh delimitation be completed before the 2029 Lok Sabha elections? May or may not. In the past, delimitation exercises took several years. The last one was set up on 12 July 2002, after the 2001 Census. Its recommendations were implemented in 2008, and the 2008 Lok Sabha elections were held based on newly drawn constituencies.

The last delimitation did not involve a reallocation of seats of individual States; only the existing constituencies within each State were redrawn. The last time Lok Sabha seats were reallocated among States was in 1973, based on the 1971 Census. That

ratio remains as of today.

The 2027 Census is the first time that data gathering has been completely digitalised. Theoretically, it is possible that the delimitation process could be quicker than before. If the exercise is not completed before the 2029 Lok Sabha elections, it could continue into the term of the next Lok Sabha and the government. The last Delimitation Commission was appointed during A. B. Vajpayee's tenure as the Prime Minister, and its work was completed during the first term of the Manmohan Singh government, with a Lok Sabha election in 2004 in between. The same can happen with the next Delimitation Commission.

What will be the mandate of the next Delimitation Commission? If a fresh delimitation is triggered under the existing provisions of Articles 81 and 82, the following will happen.

At present, the distribution of the 543 Lok Sabha seats among the States is based on the population figures of the 1971 Census. When the benchmark changes from the 1971 population to the population recorded in the first Census after 2026, the seat distribution is likely to change. Table A: Broadly speaking, the southern States are likely to face a reduction in their share of Lok Sabha seats, while the Hindi-speaking States, particularly Uttar Pradesh, Bihar and Rajasthan, are likely to gain seats. The maximum number of Lok Sabha seats allowed by the Constitution is 550. A third of the Lok Sabha seats nationally, and one-third of the seats within each State, will be reserved for women.

So, in the absence of any Constitutional amendment, the following sequence is envisaged: first, the reallocation of Lok Sabha seats among States; second, the delimitation of constituencies within States; and third, the implementation of women's reservation—all tied to the Census 2027.

How is the allocation of seats to each State determined?

Think of India as one large joint family and the States as its constituent family units. Imagine that each individual across the joint family was entitled to one acre of land (Image B). A family with five members got five acres, another with seven members got seven acres, and so on. Each family then divided its share among its members. At that point, everyone got roughly the same share. In political terms, every vote had roughly the same value. But then time passed. Some families grew much faster than others. In the larger families, the same land had to be shared among more people. In the smaller families, fewer people shared the same land. As a result, the value of each person's share began to differ.

That is, in a sense, what has happened to votes in India. In 1967, an MP across most major States represented roughly 10 to five lakh electors. Today, a MP from Kerala represents about 14 lakh electors, while in Uttar Pradesh and Bihar, the figure is around 19 lakh.

This variation is the result of a deliberate decision by all parties, taken on two occasions, in 1956 and 2000, not to punish States that had stabilised their populations. The Constitution gives that leeway. The size of Lok Sabha constituencies is not necessarily based on a national average, which today would be about 14 lakh voters per constituency. Article 81 requires seats to be allocated among States "so far as practicable", on the basis of a national average. This leeway for variation allows for a balance between two principles that can be in tension: federalism, or representation of States, and democracy, or one vote, one value. And that is the central tension the debate

Image 1

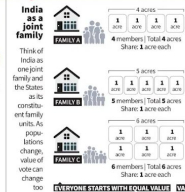
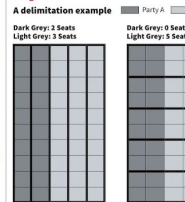


Image 2



Comparison of Lok Sabha seat distribution based on 2024 electors and 2011 population

State/ Union Territory	Current Seats (543)	Seats**	State/ Union Territory	Current Seats (543)	Seats**
A.P.	25	23	Tamil Nadu	19	15
Andhra Pradesh	14	14	Tripura	2	2
Assam	14	14	U.P.	80	86
Bihar	40	43	WB	12	12
Goa	2	1	Chhattisgarh	11	11
Gujarat	26	27	Madhya Pradesh	14	14
Haryana	10	11	Odisha	14	14
H.P.	4	3	Uttarakhand	5	5
Karnataka	20	20	Vidharbha	17	18
Kerala	20	15	Andaman & Nicobar Islands	1	0
M.P.	29	31	Chandigarh	1	0
Rajasthan	18	18	Sikkim	1	0
Madhya Pradesh	48	52	Delhi	7	6
Mizoram	1	0	Nagaland	1	1
Nagaland	1	1	Odisha	1	1
Northeast India	1	1	Punjab	13	12
Odisha	21	19	Rajasthan	25	30
Punjab	13	12	Sikkim	1	0
Rajasthan	25	30	Total	543	543
Sikkim	1	0			

on delimitation now needs to resolve.

What is gerrymandering?

When we discuss the democratic principle of One Person, One Vote, One Value, the first requirement is that every Lok Sabha constituency should have roughly the same number of voters. But equal numbers alone do not guarantee equal value for every vote. Why? Because even when constituencies contain the same number of voters, the way those voters are grouped can dramatically affect electoral outcomes.

Consider a simple example (Image 2). Imagine there are 50 voters. Party A has 20 supporters and Party B has 30 supporters. There are five constituencies, each with 10 voters and electing one representative.

In the first scenario, voters are distributed fairly across the five constituencies. The result broadly reflects the overall vote share: Party A and Party B win seats broadly in proportion to their

THE GIST

The 2027 Census is set to trigger a fresh delimitation of Lok Sabha constituencies under Articles 81 and 82, even without a new Constitutional amendment.

The exercise could significantly alter the distribution of Lok Sabha seats, with southern States likely to lose their share and Uttar Pradesh, Bihar and Rajasthan likely to gain.

Redrawing constituency boundaries could also affect electoral outcomes, as the grouping of voters through 'cracking' and 'packing' can influence which parties win seats.

Source: Gerrymandering: Everything Policy Analysts Need to Know (2021)

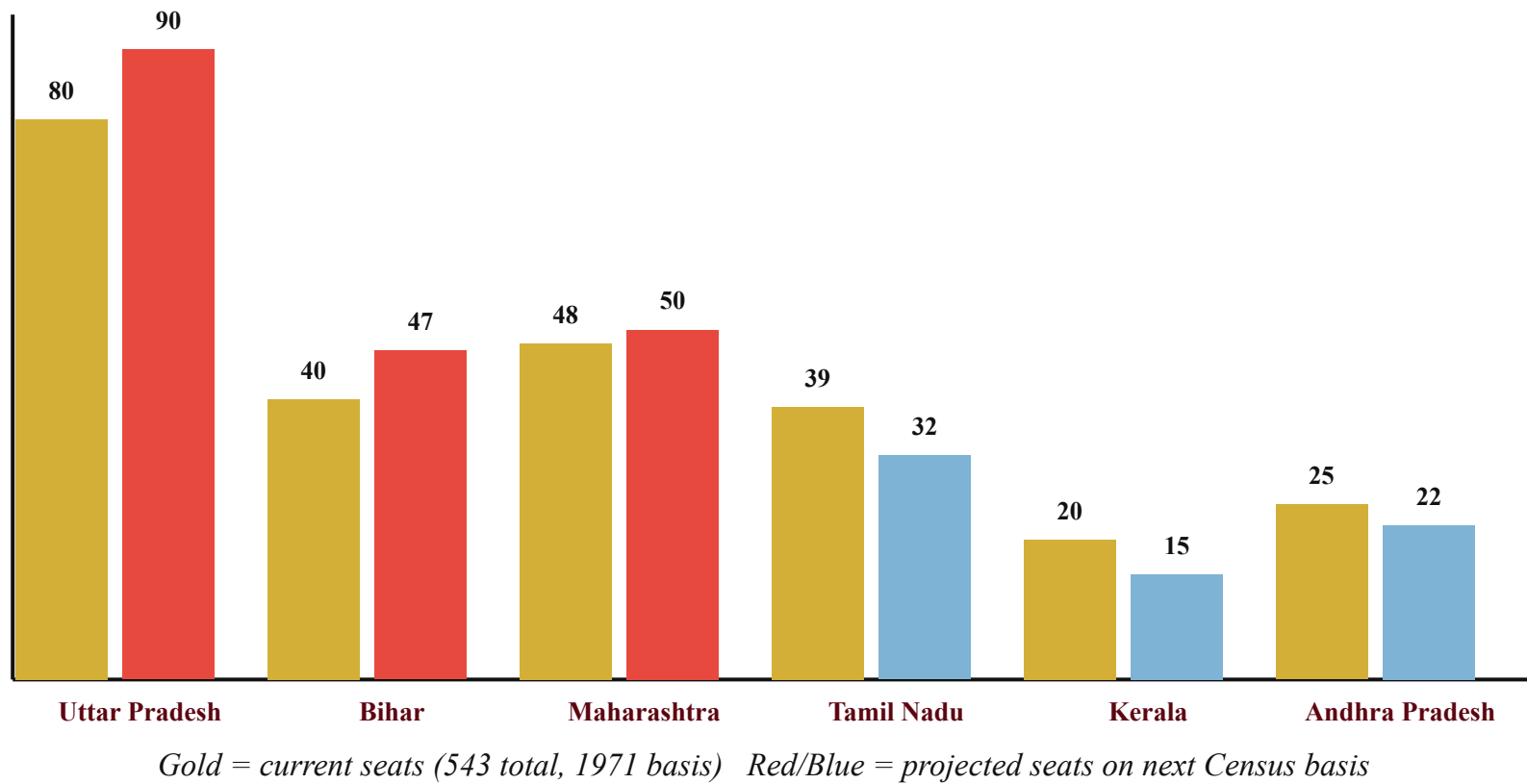
Dark Grey: 2 Seats
Light Grey: 3 Seats

Dark Grey: 0 Seats
Light Grey: 5 Seats

Dark Grey: 3 Seats
Light Grey: 2 Seats

The Stakes in India's Delimitation Debate

Who Gains, Who Loses: Projected Seat Changes (1971 → Latest Census Basis)



Centre Says Report on Theatre Commands Under Consideration

Centre says report on theatre commands under consideration

Saurabh Trivedi
NEW DELHI

The long-pending plan to operationalise theatre commands for the Indian military has entered a decisive phase, with the final report on the proposed restructuring of the armed forces now under consideration by the government, according to the latest report of the Standing Committee on Defence submitted in Parliament.

The development assumes significance as the theatrisation exercise moves into a crucial phase following the appointment of General N.S. Raja Subramani as Chief of Defence Staff (CDS) after General Anil Chauhan demitted office at the end of May.

“The final report for operationalisation of theatre commands is under consideration and further deliberations are ongoing,” the Defence Ministry told the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Defence.

The committee has classified theatre command operationalisation as the only recommendation among the 34 recommendations in the report for which a final government reply is still awaited.

The committee noted that the Joint Staff had taken the theatrisation pro-

cess to an “advanced stage”. A dedicated team comprising officers from the Army, Navy and the Air Force has been constituted under the Chief of Integrated Staff to the Chairman, Chiefs of Staff Committee (CISC), to fast-track the exercise.

Holding consultations

The committee report further reads that the three Joint Staff officers are studying global military organisations and holding consultations among the three Services to streamline the reorganisation.

Under the proposed architecture, HQ Integrated Defence Staff (IDS) will continue to coordinate operational issues involving the theatres with the three Service headquarters during the transition and thereafter. Operational coordination between theatres, as well as between theatres and the individual Services, is envisaged to be handled through a Joint Operations Staff under the structures finally approved, it reads.

The theatrisation exercise is aimed at creating a more integrated war-fighting structure by bringing the capabilities of the three Services under unified operational command structures.

Centre Says Report on Theatre Commands Under Consideration

Initial Proposal: Recommended by the 2001 Group of Ministers after the Kargil Review Committee.

Reform Panel: Reaffirmed by Shekatkar Committee (2016).

First CDS: General Bipin Rawat (appointed in 2019).

Four-Star Officer: Appointed as a four-star General, equivalent in rank to the service chiefs.

Primus Inter Pares: First among equals with the three Chiefs of Staff.

Secretary Rank: Heads the Department of Military Affairs (DMA) within the Ministry of Defence.

Oversight: Exercises administrative control over Cyber, Space, and Special Operations commands.

Appointed By: Appointments Committee of the Cabinet, chaired by the Prime Minister.

Eligibility: 3-star officers or retired 4-star officers.

Age Limit: Maximum age is 65 years.

Tenure: Serves up to age 65; no fixed term limit.

Centre Says Report on Theatre Commands Under Consideration

What are the duties of the Chief of Defence Staff (CDS) as Head of the Department of Military Affairs?

- 1. Permanent Chairman of Chiefs of Staff Committee**
- 2. Exercise military command over the three Service Chiefs**
- 3. Principal Military Advisor to Defence Minister on all tri-service matters**

Select the correct answer using the code given below:

This question was previously asked in

UPSC CSE Prelims 2024: General Studies Official Paper

 [Download PDF](#)

[Attempt Online](#)

[View all UPSC Civil Services Papers >](#)

1. 1, 2 and 3

2. 1 and 2 only

3. 2 and 3 only

4. 1 and 3 only

Thank You